

Habitus as a value lens to link customer engagement and value cocreation

Customer
engagement
and value
cocreation

Benjamin Piers William Ellway

School of Management, University of Canberra, Canberra, Australia, and

Alison Dean

University of Newcastle, Callaghan, Australia

57

Received 15 April 2019

Revised 19 August 2019

3 October 2019

5 November 2019

Accepted 5 November 2019

Abstract

Purpose – This paper uses practice theory to strengthen the theoretical relationship between customer engagement (CE) and value cocreation (VCC), thereby demonstrating how customers may become engaged and remain engaged through VCC practices.

Design/methodology/approach – The study adopts a problematization approach to identify shared assumptions evident in service-dominant logic (SDL) and CE research. Practice theory, as a higher-order perspective, is used to integrate the iterative and cyclical processes of VCC and CE, specifically through the theoretical mechanism of habitus.

Findings – Habitus acts as a customer value lens and provides a bridging concept to demonstrate how VCC and CE are joined via sensemaking processes. These processes determine how customers perceive, assess, and evaluate value, how they become engaged through VCC, and how their experience of engagement may lead to further VCC practice. The temporally bound experiences, states, and episodes are accumulated and aggregated through an enduring customer value lens comprised of habituated dispositions, interests, and attitudes.

Research limitations/implications – This work responds to calls for research to strengthen the theoretical link between VCC and CE and to take account of customers' lived realities and their contextualized experiences. A key suggestion for future research is the use of a rope metaphor to stimulate thinking about the complex, temporally unfolding, and interrelated processes of VCC and CE.

Practical implications – The customer value lens and CE rope are introduced to simplify the complex, abstract, theoretical research on VCC and CE for a nonacademic audience. To understand how customers' value lenses are formed and change, and how a CE rope is strengthened, firms, service designers, and practitioners need to understand sensemaking processes through customer narratives and to use platforms and feedback to support and trigger sensemaking.

Originality/value – This paper provides a theoretical mechanism to explain the iterative and cyclical nature of VCC and CE processes and how accumulation and aggregation occur in these processes. In doing so, it demonstrates that CE occurs by virtue of, and is typified by, sensemaking processes that reproduce and shape a customer's habituated value lens, which perceives, assesses, and determines VCC and thus provides a basis for further customer engagement.

Keywords Customer engagement, Value cocreation, Practice, Experience, Habitus, Customer value lens

Paper type Conceptual paper

1. Introduction

Scholars agree that value cocreation (VCC) and customer engagement (CE) are inextricably linked. Lusch and Vargo (2010) suggest that interactive cocreative customer experiences may be interpreted as the act of engaging, while Brodie *et al.* (2011) note that early service-dominant logic (SDL) research on VCC frequently mentioned the terms “engagement” and “engaged.” Recent recognition of the broader term actor engagement (AE) in both SDL and CE literature also confirms that these concepts are connected (Brodie *et al.*, 2019a, b; Seo *et al.*, 2017). However, the precise theoretical relationship between VCC and CE still remains unclear and warrants further elucidation (Hollebeek *et al.*, 2019; Jaakola and Alexander, 2014; Vargo and Lusch, 2016a).

Establishing the precise nature of the theoretical relationship between VCC and CE is important because Storbacka *et al.* (2016) have shown how the microfoundation of CE can be



used to advance understanding of the more macro-level foundation theory of SDL. This reflects the need to continually oscillate between micro and macro perspectives and to investigate the complexity of phenomena at the micro-level of analysis to understand macro-level phenomena (Leroy *et al.*, 2013; Vargo, 2011). As Conduit and Chen (2017) note, VCC is a transcending perspective of marketing, an umbrella term, but it “requires bridging concepts such as engagement to bring relevance to inform marketing/market practices” (p. 714). Bridging concepts enhance understanding and reflect business practice, thereby being conducive to empirical evaluation, which ultimately enables a meta-theoretic perspective to move forward (Vargo and Lusch, 2016b). This emphasis on bridging the micro and macro is reflected in the fact that engagement emerges and VCC occurs in the broader context of consumers’ social interactions (Edvardsson *et al.*, 2011) and practices (Seo *et al.*, 2017). Chandler and Lusch (2015) note the urgent need to account more fully for the influence of context, experience, and meaning making also echoed in the more recent call for “customer centric research with a focus on interactive experiences and experience of practices” (Conduit and Chen, 2017, p. 717).

This study responds to these important calls for further research on CE and VCC, and especially the need to clarify the theoretical relationship between them, by adopting a problematization approach to theorizing. We reveal three shared assumptions evident in extant CE and SDL theorizing (Alvesson and Sandberg, 2011) and demonstrate that existing perspectives are inadequate for explaining these assumptions theoretically, therefore necessitating the introduction of an alternative perspective (Locke and Golden-Biddle, 1997). The first two assumptions are (1) that CE and SDL processes are cyclical and iterative in nature, and (2) that these processes are comprised of individual temporally bound episodes, experiences, and states, while simultaneously being brought together in a process of accumulation or aggregation (Brodie *et al.*, 2011; Vargo and Lusch, 2016a). Currently, there is no theoretical mechanism to explain how accumulation and aggregation occur (Chandler and Lusch, 2015). The third assumption is that CE occurs “by virtue of” or is “typified by” value cocreative experiences (Brodie *et al.*, 2011; Jaakola and Alexander, 2014; Storbacka *et al.*, 2016). Again, there is no theoretical mechanism to explain precisely how this occurs (Hollebeek *et al.*, 2019).

To explain these three assumptions we use practice theory – a higher-order perspective and recognized meta-theoretical lens of SDL (Vargo and Lusch, 2016b) – and more specifically Bourdieu’s theory of practice and his concept of *habitus* (Bourdieu, 1977, 1990). Prior CE and SDL research has noted the potential usefulness of habitus for seeing past dispositions as a property of engagement (Chandler and Lusch, 2015), and recent research has recommended Bourdieu as an alternative perspective for investigating engagement (Brodie *et al.*, 2019a, b), but there are apparently no studies that have responded to this challenge. In contrast, consumer researchers have long employed habitus and Bourdieu’s theoretical ideas to investigate how socially and culturally situated customers develop tastes and preferences for product/service offerings and brands and how they incorporate and use these in their everyday practices (see e.g. Arsel and Bean, 2013; Arsel and Thompson, 2011; Holt, 1998; McAlexander *et al.*, 2014; Thompson and Ustuner, 2015). Bourdieu’s theoretical ideas and concepts are therefore a recognized but underutilized theoretical perspective in VCC and CE.

Habitus provides a theoretical mechanism to explain how VCC practices and CE are influenced by highly personalized and subjective individual experiences (the micro) and broader institutional and cultural norms and structures within markets (the macro) (Brodie *et al.*, 2019a, b; Chandler and Vargo, 2011). We argue that habitus can therefore be thought of as a *customer value lens*, which guides VCC practice, the perception, assessment, and evaluation of value cocreative experiences and which provides a trigger for potential CE. Briefly, this shows firms, brand managers, and service designers and practitioners that every service encounter or value cocreative episode involves an experience that is perceived and

reconciled through a customer's existing value lens, which may potentially trigger an engagement state.

By integrating and extending prior conceptualizations of VCC and CE, this study makes two contributions to service thought (MacInnis, 2011). First, we demonstrate how habitus as a customer value lens provides a theoretical mechanism to explain the iterative and cyclical processes of VCC and CE, the experientially accumulating process of creating, perceiving, assessing, and determining value (Ellway and Dean, 2016; Grönroos and Gummerus, 2014; Vargo and Lusch, 2016a), and the aggregation of engagement states into a broader engagement process (Brodie *et al.*, 2011; Hollebeek *et al.*, 2019). The habituated customer value lens demonstrates that CE occurs “by virtue of” and “is typified by” (Brodie *et al.*, 2011) sensemaking processes associated with VCC practice and experience. Second, we introduce the metaphor of the *engagement rope* as mental imagery to simplify the incredibly complex aggregation of engagement states, dimensions, and value cocreative episodes and experiences, so that aggregation can be conceived as a process of *intertwinement*. This metaphor fills a gap in extant literature because it shows how individual engagement states are aggregated into a broader engagement process that is underpinned by a customer's habituated value lens, which both informs and is informed by value cocreative experiences. The customer value lens and CE rope enable us to accommodate the theoretical complexities of VCC and CE but simplify these ideas so that they are more accessible to nonacademic audiences – service professionals and practitioners, firms, and brand managers.

The paper is structured as follows. First, the problematization approach that guides the study is outlined. A critical review of relevant literature is then used to identify key assumptions and limitations of VCC and CE research. Next, we introduce practice theory and the concept of habitus as a customer value lens. We then explain how the customer value lens helps us to explain the nature of VCC and CE processes and the relationship between them. A visual framework encompassing value cocreative experiences and engagement states is introduced, along with the notion of the CE rope, and an illustrative example is provided to illuminate the theoretical mechanisms at play. The paper concludes with theoretical contributions, future research, and practical implications.

2. A problematization approach

A problematization approach to theorizing attempts to think differently about what is already known (Foucault, 1985). For Alvesson and Sandberg (2011), problematization is a process of identifying and challenging assumptions that underpin existing literature – “the necessary presuppositions researchers make about a subject matter in order to develop the specific theory about it” (Alvesson and Sandberg, 2011, p. 253) – and then replacing them with an alternative set of assumptions. Alvesson and Sandberg (2011) identify five types of assumptions that can be problematized – *in-house*, *root metaphor*, *paradigm*, *ideology*, and *field* assumptions. Their perspective on problematization is highly critical as it involves an explicit claim that past research is “wrong” in some way. In contrast, Locke and Golden-Biddle (1997) see problematization as a process of identifying a body of literature to call into question the research that already exists by complaining that it is either *incomplete*, or *inadequate*, or *incommensurate*. This form of problematizing is less critical as only the incommensurability problematization involves the argument that past research is “wrong” in some way.

Our problematization approach was firstly guided by Alvesson and Sandberg (2011) because we identified *in-house assumptions* that underpinned extant literature. In-house assumptions “exist within a particular school of thought in the sense that they are shared and accepted as unproblematic by its advocates” (p. 254) and refer to a set of ideas held by a theoretical school about a specific subject matter or phenomenon of interest. As stated previously, the particular in-house assumptions that we identified are first, that VCC and CE

are iterative and cyclical processes; second, that those processes involve an accumulation or aggregation of individual episodes, experiences, or states; and third, that CE “occurs by virtue of” and “is typified by” the cocreation of value and corresponding cocreative experiences. To surface the three assumptions stated earlier, we followed [Alvesson and Sandberg’s \(2011\)](#) process of analyzing “exemplars” or path-defining studies ([Abbott, 2001](#); [Kuhn, 1970](#)) in CE and SDL to interrogate the assumptions that underpin them and to show how these are reproduced more broadly in other studies.

After identifying these assumptions, our problematization then departed from [Alvesson and Sandberg’s \(2011\)](#) approach because there are compelling arguments in the literature to indicate that the three assumptions are not open to challenge. Thus, we proceeded from the identification and acceptance of these assumptions to develop an *inadequacy problematization*. An inadequacy problematization “claims that work in the extant field has overlooked perspectives relevant and important to better understanding and explaining the phenomena” ([Locke and Golden-Biddle, 1997](#), p. 1047). The relevant perspective that we contend has been overlooked is Bourdieu’s practice theory and especially his concept of habitus. The potential of practice theory has been recognized in SDL as a meta-theoretical lens that underpins this school of thought ([Vargo and Lusch, 2016a](#)) but, to date, practice theory has been underutilized by CE research relative to SDL scholarship ([Storbacka et al., 2016](#)). There is, however, growing recognition of the theoretical potential of Bourdieu’s ideas in SDL literature, but his work is often cited as a general reference to practice theory (e.g. [Echeverri and Skålén, 2011](#); [Gummerus, 2013](#); [Helkkula and Kelleher, 2010](#); [Helkkula et al., 2012](#)), with a few exceptions ([Ellway, 2014b](#); [Ellway and Dean, 2016](#); [McColl-Kennedy et al., 2012, 2015](#)). In the following sections we review existing SDL and CE research to surface the three common assumptions – the key ideas held by these two schools of marketing thought – and then we introduce Bourdieu’s theory of practice as an alternative perspective to provide a stronger theoretical grounding for the ideas and to address their conceptual inadequacy ([Locke and Golden-Biddle, 1997](#)).

3. A practice–theoretical approach to SDL

VCC practices are defined as “what customers ‘think and do’ to extract or co-create value from resources in their everyday lives” (developed from [Ellway and Dean, 2016](#), p. 4). [Warde \(2005\)](#) highlighted that while practice is routine “doing,” practice also involves mental processes and builds on the past, and [Arsel and Bean \(2013, p. 901\)](#) contend that practice represents the “ongoing routines, engagements, and performances that constitute social life.” Thus, VCC practice defined as what customers “think and do,” has a behavioral emphasis, is situated in the customer’s life world, and includes personal resources and mental processes, which provide meaning and the basis for change over time ([Ellway and Dean, 2016](#)). Scholars have argued that VCC practice and VCC experience are intertwined ([Ellway and Dean, 2016](#); [Helkkula et al., 2012](#)), and VCC has even been described as “a lived or joint reality of *use and experience*” ([Ranjan and Read, 2016](#), p. 315, *emphasis added*). In the current study, experience refers to *experience of practice*, defined as “the individual’s unique and context-bound, phenomenological interpretation of value co-creation activity” ([Ellway and Dean, 2016](#), p. 5). Practice is fundamental to value creation ([Echeverri and Skålén, 2011](#); [McColl-Kennedy et al., 2012, 2015](#); [Seo et al., 2017](#)) and experience of practice necessarily occurs with reference to preceding experiences within individual circumstances and reflects the individual’s resultant cognitive and affective processes.

3.1 The iterative, cyclical, and experientially accumulating process of value cocreation

The iterative and cyclical nature of VCC is a key assumption of SDL theorizing. VCC consists of the value-generating interaction and collaboration processes within networks of actors

(Vargo and Lusch, 2008a), where value is uniquely and phenomenologically determined by those actors in a dynamic and unfolding process over time (Grönroos and Gummerus, 2014; Vargo and Lusch, 2016a). Other scholars confirm this view. For example, Helkkula *et al.* (2012, p. 61) proposed that value “is constructed based on previous, current, and imaginary future experiences and is temporal in nature.” More recently, in their review of 149 papers on VCC, Ranjan and Read (2016, p. 294) found that “joint, reciprocal, and iterative processes are the basis of the relationship between the customer and the object. . . [and] customer relational capabilities create value because they increase the possibilities to sense-and-respond and self-reinforce value cycles of dynamic exchange instead of [a] linear chain of interaction. . . resulting in connected sets of practices that are a source of value in themselves”. In their extension and update of theory, Vargo and Lusch (2016a) describe S-D logic as a cycle in which “value cocreation” is developing into one of resource-integrating, reciprocal-service-providing actors cocreating value through holistic, meaning-laden experiences in nested and overlapping service ecosystems, governed and evaluated through their institutional arrangements (p. 7). Therefore, it is apparent that as consumers incorporate service and product offerings into their daily practices to create value, which they judge through experiences of those practices, the process builds temporally in an ongoing cycle. That is, how we cocreate value with product/service offerings and our experience of it depends partly on the past, and what we do now may influence or determine how we experience and create value in the future.

The cyclical process outlined earlier leads to the second key assumption in VCC theorizing, that is, for each customer, the iterative and cyclical process is an accumulation of past experience of VCC practice. Owing to the complexity of the two phenomena – VCC practices and the related experiences – much research has tended to focus on one rather than on both of them (Helkkula *et al.*, 2012). Experience is internal and subjective (Helkkula, 2011; Akaka *et al.*, 2015) and customers actively contribute to and interpret their experiences (Gummerus, 2013). Previous research highlights customer experience as individual, dynamic, cumulative, and context-bound (e.g. Chandler and Vargo, 2011) and argues that it is built on one’s prior state of mind and previous interactions, which provide a foundation for the future (Helkkula and Kelleher, 2010; Vargo and Lusch, 2008a, b). In terms of practice, scholars have emphasized the importance of contextualizing VCC practice (Chandler and Vargo, 2011; McColl-Kennedy *et al.*, 2015), especially in relation to the social and cultural contexts in which customers perform the various activities of their daily lives (Akaka *et al.*, 2013; Edvardsson *et al.*, 2011; Ellway, 2014b) and where they enact different practices to cocreate value (McColl-Kennedy *et al.*, 2012, 2017). Thus, cocreation practice requires a focus on understanding both customers’ individual cocreation practices and how these daily practices are situated in various social and cultural contexts.

3.2 Bourdieu’s practice theory and the concept of *habitus*

Bourdieu’s theory of practice has been used extensively in consumer research. Due to the complexity and depth of his theoretical ideas, consumer researchers have typically prioritized one or two concepts over others, for example, *field* and *capital* (Arsel and Thompson, 2011; McAlexander *et al.*, 2014), *habitus* and *cultural capital* (Holt, 1998; Thompson and Ustuner, 2015), or *habitus* (Arsel and Bean, 2013; Holt, 1998). We adopt a similar approach as we prioritize *habitus* due to its centrality to the purpose of this study but, in using *habitus*, we also need to discuss *field*.

Bourdieu (1984) argues that our taste emerges through culturalization and socialization processes in early life and continuing through adulthood, which form *dispositions*, *attitudes*, and *interests* (the multilayered concept of *habitus*) in cultural and material products, objects, and activities. *Habitus* is developed through the various *fields* in which our daily practices occur, the social spaces comprised of rules, resources, and structures that guide our practice.

Fields can be smaller social spaces, such as the education field of an individual university, or much broader social spaces, such as the global field of MBA education or the academic field in any given country. Fields influence our habitus because during the time we spend in them, we are exposed to cultural norms, rules, and regulations, which structure our thinking and conduct. Through this process, the structures of fields become incorporated into our habitus – under as corresponding structures in the form of our attitudes, dispositions, and interests – which shape practice. In this respect, fields are akin to habitats – and the habitats we spend our time in contribute to the formation of our habitus. However, because as social agents – or actors in SDL terminology – we all have agency, we can always choose to do otherwise in the sense that we can reject or ignore the field and enact different structures through our practice.

Habitus provides a theoretical mechanism to demonstrate how the macro – the objective structure of social fields (or habitats) – influences the micro – our practice and highly individual and subjective experience of it (through our habitus), and vice versa. Habitus therefore shows how the active presence of past experiences influences our current practice. Crucially, [Bourdieu \(1977, 1984, 1990\)](#) argues that much practice is unconscious and habitual in nature, meaning that the incorporation of macro, institutional, and field-specific structures into our way of perceiving and evaluating the world is often implicit. However, at the same time, habitus accounts for the agency of actors and the capacity for structured improvisation because we may become aware of our habitual practice and as a consequence reflect upon and change it. Habitus therefore accounts for sensemaking in temporally unfolding processes across time and space, and agents' individual trajectories, always contextualized in the social fields in which their practice occurs. The interests, attitudes, and dispositions of habitus are both durable (they endure over time but can change) and transposable (they can be formed in one field but influence our practice in another field). In the following section we will explain how habitus can greatly assist us in understanding VCC by acting as a customer value lens, through which we perceive and evaluate market offerings, products, services, and brands, choose which of them to incorporate into our VCC practice, and consequently assess and determine the value we derive from doing so.

3.3 Habitus as customer value lens and sensemaking processes

In the context of markets and consumers, habitus represents a customer value lens because it is implicated in how we perceive and evaluate market offerings (products, services, and brands), how we incorporate these into the various aspects of our lives, and how we subsequently assess and determine their value. Habitus as a customer value lens provides a theoretical mechanism for explaining the first two assumptions in VCC and CE literature: the cyclical and iterative nature of VCC practice and experience and the accumulation of value cocreative experiences. These explanations are discussed further but first we introduce sensemaking associated with habitus.

The theoretical mechanism of habitus involves two types of sensemaking processes ([Figure 1](#)). First, as consumers, we perceive and experience VCC practice through our habitus – our customer value lens. How we experience VCC practice does not happen in a vacuum. Our perception, assessment, and determination of value are based upon our customer value lens because we experience practice through our existing dispositions, interests, and attitudes, which comprise our habitus. We refer to this first sensemaking process, where habitus is implicated in how we experience VCC practice, as *habitus-perceiving* (SP1 – sensemaking process one). The emphasis here is upon habitus always actively influencing, through past experience, our current and future VCC practice and our related experience of it. But our perception, assessment, experience, and determination of VCC practice are not only influenced by our habituated customer value lens – our experience of practice is also implicated in a process of *habitus-shaping* (SP2 – sensemaking process two). Through this second sensemaking process, our habituated customer value lens is either reproduced or changed.

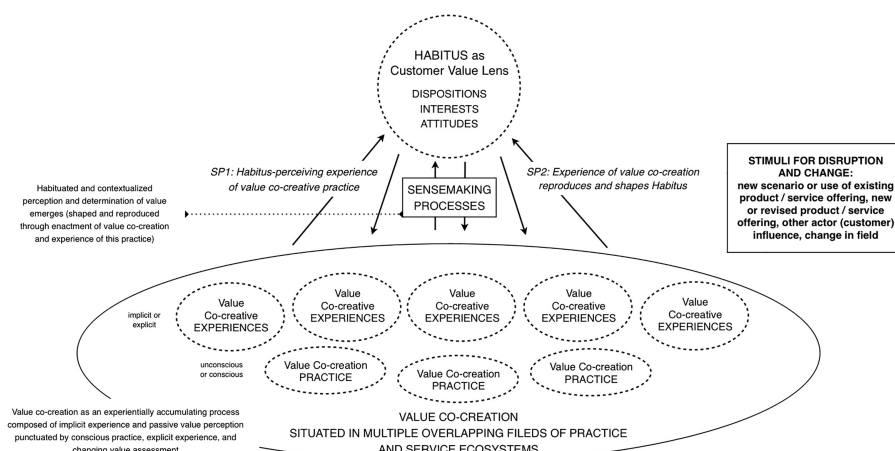


Figure 1.
Habitus as customer value lens for value cocreation practice and experience

This second sensemaking process (SP2) shows us that the value cocreative experiences of incorporating product/service offerings into our VCC practice may force us to reflect upon, question, reconsider, and subsequently modify our customer value lens. Our attitudes, interests, or dispositions toward practice and the use of different brands or product/service offerings may thus change in relation to our VCC practice and experience of it.

As indicated earlier, the customer value lens provides a theoretical explanation of the first two assumptions: the iterative and cyclical nature of VCC processes and experiential accumulation. Our habituated customer value lens “predisposes” us to certain objects and activities, to be interested in them, and to interpret them in certain ways, including perceiving and assessing their value – always based upon past experience of value cocreative practice, which is contextualized in the various fields we inhabit. But at the same time, any individual episode, scenario, or situation associated with the cocreation of value can prompt us to reflect upon our experience, how it is different, what is happening in our VCC practice, and why. Thus, experiential accumulation occurs through the customer value lens, which is at the center of the iterative and cyclical process of VCC. The habituated customer value lens therefore provides a theoretical explanation in three ways: (1) how value either emerges (see Echeverri and Skålén, 2011; Grönroos, 2011; Korkman, 2006) or is instrumentally created (Grönroos and Voima, 2013), (2) how value is both perceived and determined by individuals within social contexts (Grönroos and Gummerus, 2014), and (3) the notion that VCC practice and experience involve unconscious and anticipated/foreseen aspects (Helkkula *et al.*, 2010). The habituated aspect of the customer value lens shows that the experiential accumulation of value cocreative experiences can be unconscious and implicit, but also that the iterative and cyclical process can be disturbed or interrupted through conscious practice where experience becomes explicit, prompting possible changes in the customer value lens and how we perceive, assess, and determine future VCC. The customer value lens thus acts as a kind of filter in the sense that it helps us to “see” and “focus” on particular market offerings while ignoring others, with a change in habituated value lens “refocusing” our attention through changed interests, attitudes, or dispositions, such that we may “see” the potential value in other market offerings, or perceive and determine value differently in relation to existing offerings we already use.

In the following section we demonstrate how the habituated customer value lens also provides a theoretical mechanism for explaining the aggregation of engagement states and value cocreative experiences in the iterative and cyclical process of CE.

4. A practice–theoretical approach to customer engagement

CE is defined as “a psychological state that occurs *by virtue of* interactive, co-creative customer experiences with a focal agent/object”, where “specific CE states occur within broader, dynamic processes *typified by* the co-creation of value” (Brodie *et al.*, 2011, p. 257; *emphasis added*). That is, CE can be understood as both a customer’s psychological state (Hollebeek, 2011; Hollebeek *et al.*, 2019; Mollen and Wilson, 2010; Vivek *et al.*, 2012) and a process (Bowden, 2009; Brodie *et al.*, 2019a, b; Malthouse *et al.*, 2016). CE is more than participation in service as it reflects interactivity between focal engagement subject(s) and object(s). The process involves behavioral manifestations toward the brand or firm that may exceed transactions (Harmeling *et al.*, 2017; Jaakkola and Alexander, 2014; Van Doorn *et al.*, 2010; Verhoef *et al.*, 2010) and can be further facilitated by engagement platforms and boundary objects, which may evolve to ecosystems (Breidbach *et al.*, 2014; Storbacka *et al.*, 2016).

As with VCC processes, CE processes are also assumed to be iterative and cyclical in nature and involve the aggregation of individual engagement states and experiences (Brodie *et al.*, 2011; Chandler and Lusch, 2015; Malthouse and Calder, 2011). CE is “a dynamic and iterative process that reflects actors’ dispositions to invest resources in their interactions with other connected actors in a service system” (Brodie *et al.*, 2019a, b, p. 2). We note the reference to *dispositions*, which is also evident in work that states that engagement entails both actor disposition to engage and the activity of engaging, where engagement “will be path-dependent in terms of both the history and experience of the actor, and the routines related to the engagement” (Storbacka *et al.*, 2016, p. 3012). Storbacka *et al.* (2016) suggest that this view is conducive to the application of practice theory.

The second assumption concerning aggregation of accumulation is also evident in extant literature on CE. CE is an ongoing process that may vary in scope, complexity, and intensity at any point in time, from short-term to long-term, and relatively stable to highly variable processes, where the “engagement process may be viewed as a series of aggregated engagement states” (Brodie *et al.*, 2011, p. 259). Moreover, this aggregation is necessarily linked to antecedents and consequences of engagement. For example, the required relational CE antecedents include “participation” and “involvement,” which may also extend to coincide, or occur concurrently, with CE, while CE relational consequences may include, for example, “commitment,” “trust,” “self-brand connections,” consumers’ “emotional attachment” to focal brands, and “loyalty” (Brodie *et al.*, 2011). However, the circularity of service relationships means that such consequences may become antecedents in subsequent processes and/or cycles (Brodie *et al.*, 2011). Aggregation can be understood as process of engagement “based on actors’ present-day connections that have emerged from past service experiences and are oriented toward future service experiences” (Chandler and Lusch, 2015, p. 5).

There is, however, no theoretical mechanism to explain how isolated temporally bounded engagement states are aggregated in a process, which forms something more permanent and enduring. Put another way, there is the assumption of separate entities being joined together in a broader process, but there is no concept to explain how this happens theoretically. Given existing recognition of the importance of dispositions in CE research (Brodie *et al.*, 2019a, b; Chandler and Lusch, 2015; Storbacka *et al.*, 2016), the concept of habitus as a customer value lens provides a theoretical explanation for how dispositions emerge and change or endure in a temporally unfolding process. That is, individual, episodic, and temporally bound engagement states leave a more temporally enduring footprint on habitus, through dispositions (and interests and attitudes). The customer’s habituated value lens therefore provides a dynamic, durable, and temporally enduring concept that explains aggregation in CE. Aggregation of individual engagement states and different dimensions of engagement occurs through the strengthening or changing of dispositions, interests, and attitudes of the

habituated customer value lens. In their SDL informed framework for CE, [Hollebeek et al. \(2019\)](#) emphasize the importance of customer learning, which involves the “development of mental rules and guidelines for processing relevant brand-related information, the acquisition of new brand knowledge or insight, and ensuing behavioral modification based on new brand knowledge or insight gained” (p. 167). Habitus again provides the theoretical mechanism to explain how customer learning occurs in the process of engagement through the strengthening and shaping of their customer value lens (but not always consciously or explicitly, as we have noted in relation to our discussion of VCC). Furthermore, since habitus is always developed in relation to and through fields of practice, it is possible to explain how institutions (norms, rules) and the contextualized lived experience of actors ([Akaka et al., 2013](#); [Chandler and Vargo, 2011](#); [Ellway and Dean, 2016](#); [Seo et al., 2017](#); [Storbacka et al., 2016](#)) are implicated in engagement, through the habituated value lens, which has been formed and shaped through contextualized experiences in the various fields that customers move through in their daily lives.

5. Linking value cocreation and customer engagement through habitus

Recent studies recognize either the coexistence or interdependence of CE and VCC, with some studies highlighting value propositions or expectations as a driver of engagement ([Chandler and Lusch, 2015](#); [Jaakola and Alexander, 2014](#)). These studies tend to separate VCC and CE/AE (actor engagement) (or CE behaviors/activity) and argue that actors providing resources is a key feature of CE ([Brodie et al., 2019a, b](#); [Jaakola and Alexander, 2014](#); [Storbacka et al., 2016](#)) because resource integration is fundamental to VCC ([Chandler and Lusch, 2015](#)). Other scholars argue that engagement practices and VCC are inseparable. For example, [Seo et al. \(2017, p. 328\)](#) state “we posit that it is not possible to disentangle brand experiences and emergent value-in-use from the brand engagement practices from which they emerge”. Building on [Ellway and Dean \(2016\)](#), [Seo et al. \(2017\)](#) propose a more parsimonious model of entanglement of the concepts, in which value-in-use serves as the interface between “value co-creative brand experiences” and “brand engagement practices”. Similarly, [Hollebeek et al. \(2019\)](#) present an “S-D logic-informed” framework for CE in which they contend that “customer resource integration, in some form, extends to coincide with CE” (p. 161). Thus, there is consensus in the literature that CE and VCC are aligned, intertwined, or entangled, but a means of theoretically explaining this, or the argument that CE “occurs by virtue of” and “is typified by” the cocreation of value and experience ([Brodie et al., 2011](#)), is not yet evident. We advance [Figure 2](#) to fill this gap.

[Figure 2](#) provides a visual model that links VCC and CE through the habituated customer value lens and corresponding sensemaking processes introduced in [Figure 1](#). [Figure 2](#) shows how engagement states and the engagement process, on one hand, emerge from and are dependent upon the practice and related experience of VCC (from [Figure 1](#)), but simultaneously that engagement can contribute to and influence that same VCC process. At the center of both of these interdependent processes is the customer value lens, which perceives, assesses, and interprets VCC and engagement, but is also actively reproduced and shaped through VCC and CE. Therefore, both VCC and CE are evaluated through cognitive and affective processes, the “sensing and responding,” which result in connected sets of practices that are a source of value in themselves ([Ranjan and Read, 2016](#)). [Figure 2](#) shows that CE involves engagement states, which occur by virtue of VCC experiences, within broader, dynamic processes ([Brodie et al., 2011](#)) and importantly, cannot proceed independently of the underlying experiences ([Malthouse and Calder, 2011](#)). The experience of engagement is interpreted through the customer’s habituated value lens and also serves to reproduce or shape it, which then influences future sensemaking, engagement, and VCC practice.

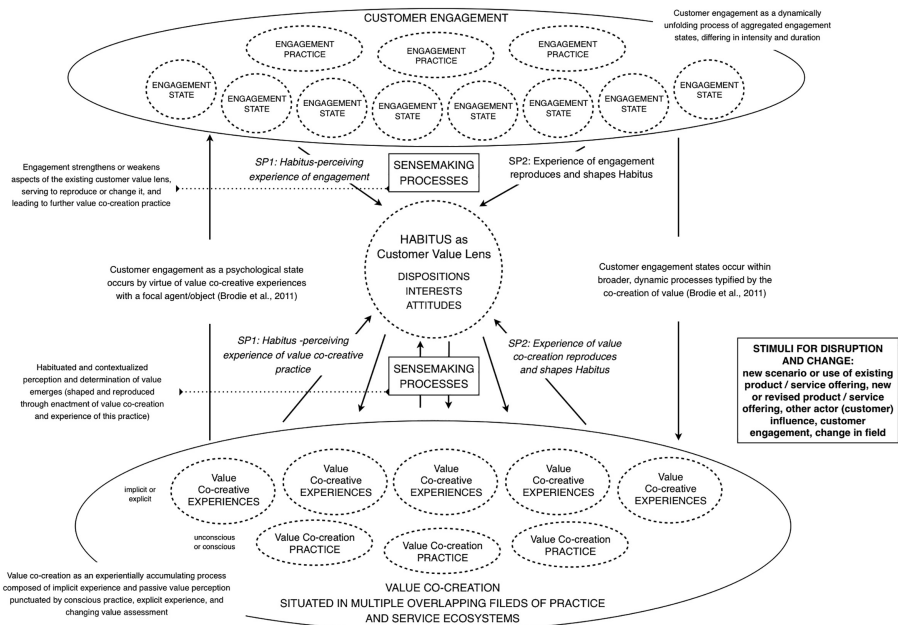


Figure 2.
A practice-based
conceptualization of
value cocreation and
customer engagement

The habitus-perceiving and habitus-shaping sensemaking processes involved in the experience and practice of VCC can therefore help us to better appreciate the practice and experience of engagement. Actors experience their VCC practice, which is at times conscious and other times unconscious, and this experience affects CE (link designated by the left vertical arrow in Figure 2) and may influence subsequent engagement states as they occur within VCC processes and operate via the habituated value lens (link designated by the right vertical arrow in Figure 2).

To illuminate the entirety of the model and the complexity of the subprocesses that comprise it, an illustrative example is provided in section 5.2. However, before using the illustrative example to illuminate the theoretical mechanisms, we introduce a metaphor – the rope – as mental imagery to simplify the complexity of the CE process.

5.1 The customer engagement rope

Metaphors have an established history of providing theoretical and practical insights, for example, *the service theater* (Grove et al., 1998; Stuart and Tax, 2004) and *the customer journey* (Ellway, 2014a; Lemon and Verhoef, 2016). Metaphors provide a way of seeing and not seeing in the sense that they draw our attention to new or previously hidden aspects or features of a phenomenon while ignoring others (Morgan, 1998). By the use of metaphor, a complex phenomenon and the abstract ideas underpinning it (*the target domain*) can be more easily appreciated and understood through a simple and more familiar phenomenon (*the source domain*). In the aforementioned two examples, service and the customer experience are the complex target domains, while the theater and journey are the more familiar source domains that offer metaphors to understand the targets. Metaphors offer a new but partial way of thinking about a phenomenon rather than providing a complete account of it (Morgan, 1998). So, for example, the service theater metaphor helps us to appreciate the on-stage and back-

stage elements of service, that front-line service employees play a role during their interactions with customers, which can be improved through customer scripts. But there is no claim that *all* aspects of a theater can be linked to and explain *all* the aspects of service.

A *rope* offers a powerful metaphor for thinking about CE. As per Morgan (1998), we are claiming that the simple everyday object of the rope (*the source domain*) can help us to see and understand CE (*the target domain*). There are four particular features of a rope that can help us to better appreciate CE and stimulate thinking about it: (1) the composition of the rope in terms of individual *threads*; (2) the process of *intertwinement* of these individual threads to form the rope; (3) the possibility that the threads differ in terms of *size, color, and length*; and (4) the fact the *strength and length* of a rope are dependent upon the corresponding length, strength, and number of individual threads that are intertwined to form it.

First, engagement states and dimensions of engagement (emotional, affective, behavioral), and the value co-creative practices and experiences upon which they are based, essentially represent *individual threads or fibers*, which collectively form the process of engagement – or the rope. Second, the rope can help us to better understand the complexity of aggregation and accumulation processes in terms of a distinctive feature of a rope – *intertwinement* – which involves the tying together of the individual threads. The aggregation and accumulation in the iterative and cyclical processes of VCC and CE are more than the simple arithmetic addition of individual elements. The process of intertwinement of threads in a rope succinctly and clearly captures the more complex nature of the aggregation and accumulation processes. Thus, the individual threads of isolated and temporally bound engagement states, value cocreative practices, and experiences associated with sensemaking processes can be thought of as becoming intertwined in a dynamic and temporally unfolding process – thus forming an engagement rope. Third, a rope commonly contains threads of different *size, color, and length*. The size and color of a thread may change, becoming a different color or becoming thicker or thinner. Changes in the color of the threads reflect the fact that antecedents can become consequences, which in turn can become further antecedents. Similarly, individual threads can differ in thickness, which reflects the fact that a particular engagement state or dimension may be more important or impactful than another, based upon the corresponding VCC experience of practice from which it emerges. Individual threads may also differ in length, which is reflective of the fact that to endure, temporally bound engagement states or dimensions must be linked to ongoing value cocreative experiences if they are to last beyond an individual episode or experience. That is, although engagement can reproduce and strengthen the customer's value lens, without reoccurring VCC and corresponding experiences unfolding over time, the temporally bound engagement state ceases to have a more temporally enduring existence in a longer process of engagement. Finally, the *strength and length* of the rope can also be thought of in terms of the intensity and temporal duration of engagement, which are dependent upon the corresponding number, thickness, and length of the individual threads, and more importantly how tightly they become intertwined.

The rope metaphor therefore helps us to think about the complex, iterative, cyclical aggregation process of CE through the mental imagery of a simple everyday object. The process of intertwinement that is fundamental to every rope also provides a further and arguably more important insight. Through the process of intertwinement, it becomes difficult to pull apart or separate the individual threads, to see where one ends and another begins, or to appreciate precisely how the threads are intertwined. Ten ropes could all differ dramatically in their size, color, and number of threads, but common to all of them is that intertwinement forms the rope and is crucial to its corresponding strength. The implication for CE research is that theoretically it may be difficult to identify and isolate individual threads of engagement in simple cause and effect relationships based upon universal laws. Rather, it might be more realistic – and useful – to first acknowledge the existence of many different types of engagement states, dimensions, and overlapping

antecedents/consequences (the colors, size, and number of threads), and second to acknowledge that how these become intertwined may differ considerably between customers and the various value cocreative practices they enact.

5.2 *An illustrative example: the overworked and stressed academic*

This section provides an illustrative example to highlight the theoretical mechanisms associated with the customer value lens and engagement rope.

5.2.1 Chris. Chris is an early-career academic. His university's new strategic plan sets out an impact agenda, so in addition to his existing academic research practice of maintaining his publishing pipeline, increasing his citations and *H*-index, and seeking funding, he now has to figure out how his research impacts business and society. This change in university policy (*a structure in the academic field*) is mirrored in other universities due to changing government policy for university funding (*the national academic field*). Chris is struggling to cope with the added pressure and stress associated with this change, not just because it has increased his workload but because he sees academic work as theoretical work – his PhD supervisor and the department were very theoretically focused, so he enjoys conceptual work and is disinterested in practice (*his theoretical academic habitus shaped from prior experience in a field*). Due to the policy change, the past three months have been tough: Chris wakes up tired, his body is stiff, his sleep is often interrupted as he can't "switch-off" before bed, his daily cup of coffee has become three, and he is hardly involved in any physical activity (*changing dispositions and practices*). His habitual practice has gradually emerged, being neither planned nor entirely conscious, and his habitus is struggling to respond to the changing impact agenda because this modified structure of the academic field of practice is misaligned with his habituated dispositions toward theoretical academic work.

5.2.2 Goopa. Goopa, Chris's colleague and friend, arrives back from doing fieldwork on transformative service initiatives in India. Due to yoga's ancestral roots in her motherland, Goopa practiced yoga when she was younger but she stopped as work and other responsibilities took over (*exposure to other fields of practice influences habitus and changes in practice*). Returning home and seeing people practice yoga at sunset and sunrise reminded her of the warmth and energy it gave her (*a habitus-shaping sensemaking episode triggered by a memory of her prior VCC practice*). Goopa began practicing yoga again during the first week (*becoming redisposed through a modified customer value lens*) and continued everyday thereafter, feeling calmer and more able to maintain focus at work for longer periods of time (*an experientially accumulating process of sensemaking perceived through the customer value lens, which strengthened her disposition to yoga practice based upon her assessment and determination of value*). By the start of the second week, she was doing yoga in the evenings to relax before bed (*further strengthening her customer value lens based upon experience of cocreative practice*). This change stimulated Goopa to get to know the locals, with whom she discussed the different forms and schools of yoga – gatherings from which she always left feeling energized (*involvement and participation emerge based upon prior experience of value cocreative practice, prompting further habitus-forming sensemaking processes to strengthen the habituated dispositions to yoga in her customer value lens*).

5.2.3 Chris and Goopa have lunch. On his way to meet Goopa, Chris passes a poster in this favorite coffee shop – "Breathe Better, Feel Better" – advertising yoga classes for "stressed out executives and busy professionals," promising "immediate benefits and a more balanced life." Mumbo jumbo, he thinks – success in his academic practice is based upon hard thinking and lots of it (*his habituated value lens perceives yoga to be an airy-fairy idea so he dismisses the value proposition*). During their lunch, Goopa talks about her rediscovery of yoga, describing the benefits she has realized from it, and suggests that Chris should try it – if only to loosen up his back! (*the recent experientially accumulating and explicit experience of her VCC practice of yoga is still fresh in her mind, and she is clearly engaged, which prompts her attempt to influence*

the VCC practice of her friend). Chris is adamant “he has no time for that,” yoga “will probably make it worse anyway,” and “his back isn’t his major concern, his work is!” (*his customer value lens differs dramatically from Goopa’s, evaluating yoga as holding no potential value for him, and thus being disinterested in the value proposition*).

5.2.4 The deadline and the yoga class. The following day, with a deadline for submission to a special issue looming, Chris becomes anxious and calls Goopa, who agrees to read his draft and provide feedback on the condition that he comes to a yoga class. With Goopa’s help, he submits the paper on time. He is still not really interested in the yoga class, but he does reflect upon his friend’s success and happiness and how she helped him to meet the deadline (*a habitus-shaping sensemaking process prompted by the value cocreative episode*). Chris reluctantly goes to the yoga class and becomes consciously aware of his breathing practice – slowing it down during the session – and immediately feeling his body relax as a consequence (*a habitus-shaping sensemaking process arising from the experience of VCC practice*). He can’t actually recall ever being conscious of his breathing patterns in the past. How does he usually breathe? – unevenly and often with short breaths because he is always thinking and caught up in the multiple demands of academic life (*a habitus sensemaking process where he questions how the structures of academic field have impacted upon his habitus*). He has a drink with Goopa and other members of the class, where they discuss the benefits of yoga and importance of seeing yoga as a tool – to strengthen the body and mind and to create a more balanced approach to a busy and demanding life (*engaged actors discussing their VCC with others*). That evening when Chris recalls this conversation, he reflects upon the notion of tools in academic practice and realizes that his perception of tools has been limited to technological ones – his laptop, his specialist writing and data analysis software, and of course his brain – rather than “softer” tools such as yoga (*his attitude and disposition to academic tools in his habituated value lens is changing, having broken his habitual practice and opened up the possibility of cocreating value differently*).

5.2.5 Practicing yoga and becoming a member. Chris signs up for a three-month course of yoga classes at the same studio and for the following fortnight he attends class twice a week and is introduced to different aspects of yogic practice, including the philosophy behind it, the emphasis on the mind–body connection, and on the importance of “flow” (*his customer value lens is now predisposed to considering the potential value of yoga as a cocreative practice*). His instructor suggests that a caffeine-free herbal tea will assist his breathing so he tries one at the yoga studio and for the rest of the day feels calmer – after the next class he buys a pack of tea to take home, which will replace his coffee (*his modified customer value lens is now interested in exploring how a related product/service offering can be incorporated into his VCC practice, with this sensemaking process situated in the social field and contextualized relative to other market offerings*). Two weeks since starting yoga, he feels more flexible, sits up straighter in his chair, does regular stretching during work at his desk, and goes for short walks at least twice each day (*his changing habitus begins to influence his value cocreative academic practice outside of the yoga classes*). Chris supplements the formal classes with daily practice at home and notices that he is less stressed, can focus for longer, and has even begun to see the impact agenda as a conceptual puzzle – how to relate his theoretical ideas to laypersons, see himself as a service provider and questioning how his ideas, models, and frameworks may help real-world practitioners (*the experientially accumulating process of value cocreative episodes further strengthens his changing habituated value lens and opens up the possibility of further VCC*). Chris purchases his own yoga mat – he has been using a spare at the yoga studio – and starts to socialize with members of the yoga class (*involvement and emerging engagement arising from his value cocreative experiences, interpreted and assessed through his modified customer value lens*).

5.2.6 Becoming engaged. Chris subscribes to a YouTube yoga channel and enjoys reading others’ experiences as they resonate with his own (*participation and involvement, further*

evidence of emerging engagement). The stories and experiences in the comments section strike an emotional chord with Chris, reinforce his thinking about the power of yoga, and prompt him to post his own comments after each session (*emotional and cognitive engagement threads forming the start of his CE rope*). The positivity he feels from the YouTube channel and its members prompts him to introduce two colleagues from work to yoga, while he also agrees to record an interview for the yoga studio he attends because he feels a connection between the values of the studio and his own personal values (*intertwining of self-brand connections and loyalty threads in the engagement rope, continuation of participation and involvement, triggering VCC with other actors*). His initial purchase of the noncaffeine tea and its realized benefits prompt him to purchase an essential oil burner, a salt lamp, and a book “using yoga for work performance” from two companies – one recommended by the YouTube channel and another by the instructor at the studio (*customer value lens predisposed to incorporating broader well-being marketplace offerings into his daily academic and life practice, VCC practice influenced by engagement platforms*).

5.2.7 Cocreating value and strengthening engagement. Two months have passed when Chris and Goopa next meet for lunch at work. This time, both friends bring energy and enthusiasm to their conversation. Chris has learned to manage his time more effectively, improve his performance at work and more importantly, his well-being. Goopa comments on this change and his enthusiasm for practicing yoga and his revised philosophy toward living and being (*changed customer value lens and value cocreative practice*). When Chris mentions his regular involvement and participation in the YouTube channel, the yoga studio, and introduction of two colleagues to Yoga, Goopa is delighted and jokes – “Wow you really are engaged, you’ll be a yogic guru soon!” (*frequency of VCC practice, value cocreative episodes, leading to engagement supported by and contributing to online and offline engagement platforms*). Goopa’s comment causes Chris to pause and reflect for a moment because he has become very engaged and he is not really sure how because while he made some decisions, the rest just seemed to happen (*emergence of VCC practice and interdependence with engagement, accumulation, and aggregation of value cocreative experiences and engagement states occurs but is not always an explicit and conscious process*). “So how did all this happen, just because I convinced you to go to that first yoga class?” Goopa asks. “Er. . .”, Chris begins, and then pauses again because there are so many individual threads to the emergence of his VCC practice and engagement, which are difficult to precisely untangle. Seeing that Chris is struggling with the question, Goopa decides to go to the restroom – “Have a think about it, I’ll be back in a few minutes!” Chris reflects upon his journey – the first few weeks were crucial because they involved so many positive experiences, which opened him up to a new way of thinking, a new way to approach his academic practice, and increased his appreciation of the connection between his physical and mental well-being. And one thing led to another, one positive episode led to another, with the different episodes, experiences, and states becoming intertwined, one morphing into another, which in turn only strengthened his resolve and interest. He now recognizes how fundamentally his views and beliefs have changed and how complex the intertwined threads of his value cocreative and engagement journey are. And that gives him an idea. Goopa returns and asks, “So?!” Chris smiles, “Well, it’s a complicated story. It is much easier to explain it if we think in terms of a lens and rope. . .”

6. Theoretical contribution

This paper has been guided by a problematization methodology, which firstly sought to reveal assumptions evident in extant literature – the shared ideas held by a theoretical school (Alvesson and Sandberg, 2011) – and secondly argued that existing perspectives were inadequate to explain these assumptions, thus necessitating the introduction of an alternative perspective (Locke and Golden-Biddle, 1997). We identified three assumptions and shared

ideas – the iterative and cyclical nature of VCC and CE processes; the aggregation or accumulation of experiences and engagement states in VCC and CE processes; and finally, that CE is “typified by” and “occurs by virtue of” value cocreative experiences. We argued that there was no theoretical mechanism to explain these assumptions and consequently introduced Bourdieu’s practice theory and his habitus concept as an alternative perspective.

Through this problematization, we provide a conceptual contribution to VCC and CE theorizing (MacInnis, 2011). *Conceptual integration* is a form of relating that involves seeing something in a new way by *finding a higher-order perspective* on how entities are related, including revealing similarities between or connecting together entities, often by *introducing simplicity to tackle recognized complexity* (MacInnis, 2011, *emphasis added*). This paper has introduced the higher-order perspective of Bourdieu’s practice theory and habitus as a theoretical mechanism to explain the three assumptions and to conceptually integrate the processes of VCC and CE. Habitus as a customer value lens provides a bridging concept for the iterative and cyclical, experientially accumulating, process of VCC practice and experience, and for the interdependent process of CE, involving the aggregation of individual engagement states. The habituated customer value lens provides a *temporally enduring* theoretical mechanism to explain how *temporally bounded* value cocreative episodes, experiences, and engagement states are aggregated and accumulated. Thus, CE occurs “by virtue of” sensemaking processes associated with the customer value lens, which interpret and assess experiences and determine the VCC practice more broadly, which in turn triggers CE, again interpreted and experienced through the customer value lens, and being “typified by” the ongoing cocreation of value and value cocreative experiences (Brodie *et al.*, 2011).

Habitus as a customer value lens has significant potential as a theoretical mechanism because it *acts upon* VCC and CE processes – by influencing what customers are interested in, what they are disposed to do, and their attitude toward objects and doings, and how they perceive their related experiences and assess and determine the value of them and their practice – but is also *acted upon* by VCC and CE processes, because VCC practice, experience of it, and potential engagement similarly reproduce or modify the customer’s value lens. The habituated customer value lens therefore accounts for the joining of the micro-level individual experience of value cocreative practice and engagement, with broader macro-level social and cultural rules and arrangement (Brodie *et al.*, 2019a, b; Storbacka *et al.*, 2016). The habituated customer value lens can be modified by those value cocreative experiences, which shows theoretically how a revised perceptive evaluative lens is provided for further practice and experience, thereby creating a recursive cycle (Chandler and Lusch, 2015; Ellway and Dean, 2016; Seo *et al.*, 2017). The habituated customer value lens also shows how individual cocreative experiences and engagement states become accumulated into the customer’s value lens for perceiving, assessing, and determining their VCC practice (Grönroos and Gummerus, 2014; Vargo and Lusch, 2016a, b). We have therefore demonstrated how habitus-perceiving and habitus-forming sensemaking processes can explain triggers for engagement and subsequently lead to further customer-initiated VCC for the central actor and/or other customers. Our conceptualization explains the circularity of engagement and cocreation processes and their interrelationships with practice and experience, which, as iterative processes built on mental models, show that the consequences of one process become the antecedents of another (Helkkula *et al.*, 2012; Ranjan and Read, 2016).

We used the mental imagery of the customer value lens and the CE rope in an attempt to simplify VCC and CE for a nonacademic audience. This reflects the nature of conceptualization as a “process of abstract thinking involving the mental representation of an idea. . . ‘seeing or ‘understanding’ something abstract, in one’s mind” (MacInnis, 2011, p. 140). As academic research on VCC and CE progresses, the more we realize the inherent complexity in the phenomena and the necessary sophistication in the theoretical ideas required to explain them. Take, for example, the complexity inherent within CE. Brodie *et al.*

(2011) distinguish between emotional, affective, and behavioral dimensions of engagement; identify CE levels/valence; and show that engagement has both antecedents and consequences, and that over time, antecedents can become consequences in future processes. [Fehrer et al. \(2013\)](#) uncovered over 50 antecedents and consequences associated with CE and note that some were overlapping. Moreover, [Fehrer et al. \(2018\)](#) distinguished between engagement disposition, engagement behavior, and engagement connectedness, while [Hollebeek et al. \(2019\)](#) introduce three CE foundational processes and the concepts of “CE-enablers,” “CE-facilitators,” and “CE benefits/detriments.” Capturing this complexity and explaining it in a way that makes it accessible to a nonacademic audience represents a significant challenge. In the final section, we discuss how the customer value lens and the engagement rope might simplify complex and sophisticated theoretical ideas for our nonacademic audience and subsequently provide some guidance about how they might use them. Before doing so, we consider potential avenues for future research.

7. Future research

An agenda for future research conventionally discusses a number of research themes and identifies corresponding questions for each. The theoretical endeavor of this article, however, was to provide conceptual integration ([MacInnis, 2011](#)) by providing a theoretical mechanism to link VCC and CE processes through the bridging concept of habitus. Therefore, having identified the shared assumptions of VCC and CE processes and then linked these through the sensemaking processes associated with the customer’s value lens, it would appear odd that a simpler higher-order theoretical perspective should be followed by an agenda that differentiates areas and then further divides these into targeted questions. Therefore, having attempted to provide a modest contribution to SDL and CE research through conceptual integration, we believe that future research might also benefit from exploring a higher-order perspective. Specifically, rather than articulating divergent lines of investigation for researchers, we instead suggest that exploring the potential of metaphor may stimulate researchers to conceive of interesting ideas for thinking about the theory and practice of VCC and CE.

The features of the engagement rope metaphor trigger interesting questions that might assist conceptual thinking about CE and VCC. Is the engagement rope strongest when the cognitive, affective, and behavioral dimensions or threads of engagement coexist? Will the threads of the engagement rope “thin” and potentially break if the duration or gaps between the individual engagement states and corresponding value cocreative practices and experiences are too long? Does the intensity or length of the engagement state create a stronger engagement rope at that point in time, or does it have a more temporally enduring impact? Does the intertwining of more individual engagement threads result in a stronger engagement rope? It also seems reasonable to assume that each time a customer enacts a cocreation practice, is exposed to a new/modified service offering, or encounters a particular situation or VCC episode, the individual threads of the rope might be strengthened or weakened.

A further insight prompted by the rope metaphor is that the individual threads of CE and VCC may be difficult to empirically separate or disentangle within any precision. As the illustrative example of the overworked academic demonstrates, multiple overlapping events and episodes comprise the temporally unfolding process of VCC practice and CE. It is difficult to isolate the individual sensemaking processes, implicit and explicit experiences, conscious or unconscious practices, and engagement states that comprise the complex world of human practice in cause and effect relationships. This resonates with prior conceptual work on the antecedents and consequences of engagement (such as involvement and participation, and commitment, loyalty, emotional attachment, trust, and self-brand connections), which may

coincide or involve consequences becoming future antecedents (Brodie *et al.*, 2011), thus showing the complexity and multiplicity of engagement processes. Following their identification of antecedents and consequences associated with CE (as noted earlier) (Fehrer *et al.*, 2013), Fehrer *et al.* (2014) found inconsistency in the cause–effect relationships, which they suggested could be due to variations in the underlying conceptualizations. But it is also possible that the reason for this inconsistency and the broader problem with attempting to separate the multitude of different antecedents, and then link them together, is that the real-world phenomenon of CE might be too difficult to model as a hypoductive model of cause and effect relationships based upon constructs and variables. Perhaps the efforts of researchers to produce variance theory by isolating and measuring these individual entities in the hope of explaining their specific impact upon each other may prove unproductive. Instead, focusing on process theory by investigating the richness of experiences, the critical incidents in VCC practice, the manifestation of sensemaking processes, and the corresponding changes in or reproduction of the value lenses of customer will prove to be more interesting in advancing our understanding of these complex real-world processes.

8. Practical implications

This study has four main practical implications.

First, firms must adopt a customer perspective to recognize the importance of sensemaking episodes and processes. Service processes and systems must be explicitly designed to incorporate opportunities for sensemaking episodes that confirm or strengthen a customer's value lens or change it in relation to firm-provided and customer-interpreted value propositions. The customer perspective recognizes the multiplicity of contexts within which VCC takes place – the social spaces and domains of practice where customers utilize and incorporate service/product offerings into their daily lives. This perspective is important because many of these sensemaking processes are highly personal, individualistic, and context-specific, despite being situated within and influenced by broader fields of service. How might they do this? We believe that it is important to challenge assumptions about customer-perceived value and explore what has led to engagement, under what circumstances, rather than focusing totally on the types and outcomes of engagement.

The second implication concerns customer processes. Sensemaking is an internal customer process so the question becomes how to penetrate and influence the customer experience so that it leads to positive emotions and cognitions, which reinforce the perceived value proposition and strengthen engagement in the service relationship. We suggest that customer narratives – which describe the complex, not always explicit, and highly personal nature of VCC, are a particularly useful source of understanding how and why customers become and remain engaged. Customer narratives provide rich data into how the complex, multifaceted nature of VCC and engagement plays out in practice. What constitutes the individual threads of the engagement rope for a customer and how do they become intertwined in an engagement process?

Third, platforms need to be used to support sensemaking processes. Wider customer engagement within the customer's ecosphere, when public, provides a listening device with which managers can supplement customer narratives. Scholars have recognized the importance of engagement platforms (e.g. Breidbach *et al.*, 2014; Chandler and Lusch, 2015) and we add that these can be usefully seen as sensemaking platforms to trigger and maintain engagement. Such engagement platforms need to be accessible and easy to use, or they will serve to diminish the further experience and likely affect the customer value lens in a negative way, by exposing negative outcomes of VCC practices, instead of being a potential vehicle to drive wider engagement and benefits for the firm.

Finally, firms should aim to use positive and negative feedback. One of the most important roles of service managers is to get customers to complain so that managers can take appropriate actions on the part of a firm. The engaged customer is more likely to give feedback to the company, thereby contributing their views with respect to the service offering (what Jaakkola and Alexander (2014) refer to as “codeveloping behavior”) (Hollebeek *et al.*, 2019). Hence, managers need to encourage both positive and negative customer engagement; positive actions provide outreach into new networks and communities (including the firm itself), and negative engagement, or complete disengagement, should stimulate action by the firm. While it is well recognized that companies need to develop specific skills and competencies, it is important that managers also consider their own mind-sets. Technology empowers customers to engage and cocreate beyond firm borders; the issue is the extent to which managers are prepared to empower them and enable them to engage and cocreate further within firm borders. This question concerns traditions embedded in social structures and associated roles (Edvardsson *et al.*, 2011) and who is in control of resources (Vargo and Lusch, 2008b). We suggest that managers seeking to gain from extended CE opportunities need to identify potential operational barriers. That is, our conceptualization reinforces the shift from a firm-dominant view of processes and suggests an alternative approach that is built on the customer’s worldview, experience, and sensemaking.

References

- Abbott, A. (2001), *Time Matters: On Theory and Method*, The University of Chicago Press, Chicago, UA.
- Akaka, M.A., Vargo, S.L. and Lusch, R.F. (2013), “The complexity of context: a service ecosystems approach for international marketing”, *Journal of International Marketing*, Vol. 21 No. 4, pp. 1-20.
- Akaka, M.A., Vargo, S.L. and Schau, H.J. (2015), “The context of experience”, *Journal of Service Management*, Vol. 26 No. 2, pp. 206-223.
- Alvesson, M. and Sandberg, J. (2011), “Generating research questions through problematization”, *Academy of Management Review*, Vol. 36 No. 2, Published Online:1 Apr 2011, doi: [10.5465/amr.2009.0188](https://doi.org/10.5465/amr.2009.0188).
- Arsl, Z. and Bean, J. (2013), “Taste regimes and market-mediated practice”, *Journal of Consumer Research*, Vol. 40 February, pp. 899-917.
- Arsl, Z. and Thompson, C. (2011), “Demythologizing consumption practices: how consumers protect their field- dependent capital from devaluing marketplace myths”, *Journal of Consumer Research*, Vol. 37 February, pp. 791-806.
- Bourdieu, P. (1977), *Outline of a Theory of Practice*, Cambridge University Press, Cambridge.
- Bourdieu, P. (1984), *Distinction: A Social Critique of the Judgement of Taste*, Routledge Classics.
- Bourdieu, P. (1990), *The Logic of Practice*, Polity Press, Cambridge.
- Bowden, J.L. (2009), “The process of customer engagement: a conceptual framework”, *Journal of Marketing Theory and Practice*, Vol. 17 No. 1, pp. 63-74.
- Breidbach, C.F., Brodie, R.J. and Hollebeek, L. (2014), “Beyond virtuality: from engagement platforms to engagement ecosystems”, *Managing Service Quality*, Vol. 24 No. 6, pp. 592-611.
- Brodie, R.J., Fehrer, J.A., Jaakkola, E. and Conduit, J. (2019a), “Actor engagement in networks: defining the conceptual domain”, *Journal of Service Research*, Vol. 22 No. 2, pp. 1-16.
- Brodie, R.J., Fehrer, J.A., Jaakkola, E. and Conduit, J. (2019b), “Actor engagement in networks: defining the conceptual domain”, *Journal of Service Research*, Vol. 22 No. 2, pp. 173-188.
- Brodie, R.J., Hollebeck, L.D., Juric, B. and Ilic, A. (2011), “Customer engagement: conceptual domain, fundamental propositions, and implications for research”, *Journal of Service Research*, Vol. 14 No. 3, pp. 252-271.

- Chandler, J.D. and Lusch, R.F. (2015), "Service systems a broadened framework and research agenda on value propositions, engagement, and service experience", *Journal of Service Research*, Vol. 18 No. 1, pp. 6-22.
- Chandler, J.D. and Vargo, S.L. (2011), "Contextualization and value-in-context: how context frames exchange", *Marketing Theory*, Vol. 11 No. 1, pp. 35-49.
- Conduit, J. and Chen, T. (2017), "Transcending and bridging co-creation and engagement: conceptual and empirical insights", *Journal of Service Theory and Practice*, Vol. 27 No. 4, pp. 714-720.
- Echeverri, P. and Skålén, P. (2011), "Co-creation and Co-destruction: a practice-theory based study of interactive value formation", *Marketing Theory*, Vol. 11 No. 3, pp. 351-373.
- Edvardsson, B., Tronvoll, B. and Gruber, T. (2011), "Expanding understanding of service exchange and value co-creation: a social construction approach", *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, Vol. 39 No. 2, pp. 327-339.
- Ellway, B.P.W. (2014a), "The voice-to-technology (V2T) encounter and the call centre servicescape: navigation, spatiality and movement", *Journal of Service Management*, Vol. 25 No. 3, pp. 349-368.
- Ellway, B.P.W. (2014b), "Using practice theory to analyse value propositions and value facilitation in self-reliance training", *International Journal of Services, Economics and Management*, Vol. 6 No. 2, pp. 181-192.
- Ellway, B.P.W. and Dean, A.M. (2016), "The reciprocal intertwining of practice and experience in value creation processes", *Marketing Theory*, Vol. 16 No. 3, pp. 299-324.
- Fehrer, J.A., Woratschek, H. and Germelmann, C.C. (2013), "Antecedents and consequences of customer engagement – a literature review", *Australian & New Zealand Marketing Academy Conference (ANZMAC)*, Auckland, December 1-3.
- Fehrer, J.A., Woratschek, H., Germelmann, C.C. and Brodie, R.J. (2018), "Dynamics and drivers of customer engagement: within the dyad and beyond", *Journal of Service Management*, Vol. 29 No. 3, pp. 443-467.
- Fehrer, J.A., Woratschek, H., Germelmann, C.C. and Brodie, R.J. (2014), "Conceptualizing the dynamic and iterative nature of customer engagement", *43th European Marketing Academy Conference (EMAC)*, Valencia, June 3-6.
- Foucault, M. (1985), *The Use of Pleasure: History of Sexuality*, Vol. 2, Vintage Books, New York.
- Grönroos, C. (2011), "Value co-creation in service logic: a critical analysis", *Marketing Theory*, Vol. 11 No. 3, pp. 279-301.
- Grönroos, C. and Gummerus, J. (2014), "The service revolution and its marketing implications: service logic vs. service-dominant logic", *Managing Service Quality*, Vol. 24 No. 3, pp. 206-229.
- Grönroos, C. and Voima, P. (2013), "Critical service logic: making sense of value creation and co-creation", *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, Vol. 41 No. 2, pp. 133-150.
- Grove, S.J., Fisk, R.P. and Dorsch, M.J. (1998), "Assessing the theatrical components of the service encounter: a cluster analysis examination", *Service Industries Journal*, Vol. 18 No. 3, pp. 116-134.
- Gummerus, J. (2013), "Value creation processes and value outcomes in marketing theory: strangers or siblings?", *Marketing Theory*, Vol. 13 No. 1, pp. 19-46.
- Harmeling, C.M., Moffett, J.W., Arnold, M.J. and Carlson, B.D. (2017), "Toward a theory of customer engagement marketing", *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, Vol. 45, pp. 312-335.
- Helkkula, A. and Kelleher, C. (2010), "The circularity of customer service experience and customer perceived value", *Journal of Consumer Behaviour*, Vol. 9 No. 1, pp. 37-53.
- Helkkula, A., Kelleher, C. and Pihlström, M. (2012), "Practices and experiences: challenges and opportunities for value research", *Journal of Service Management*, Vol. 23 No. 4, pp. 554-570.

- Hollebeek, L.D., Srivastava, R.K. and Chen, T. (2019), "S-D logic-informed customer engagement: integrative framework, revised fundamental propositions, and application to CRM", *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, Vol. 47 No. 1, pp. 161-185.
- Holt, D.B. (1998), "Does cultural capital structure American consumption?", *Journal of Consumer Research*, Vol. 25 No. 1, pp. 1-25.
- Jaakkola, E. and Alexander, M. (2014), "The role of customer engagement behavior in value co-creation a service system perspective", *Journal of Service Research*, Vol. 17 No. 3, pp. 247-261.
- Korkman, O. (2006), *Customer Value Formation in Practice: A Practice-Theoretical Approach*, [Dissertation], Hanken School of Economics, Helsinki.
- Kuhn, T.S. (1970), *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*, Chicago University Press, Chicago.
- Lemon, K.N. and Verhoef, P.C. (2016), "Understanding customer experience throughout the customer journey", *Journal of Marketing*, Vol. 80 No. 6, pp. 69-96.
- Leroy, J., Cova, B. and Salle, R. (2013), "Zooming in vs zooming out on value co-creation: consequences for BtoB research", *Industrial Marketing Management*, Vol. 42 No. 7, pp. 1102-1111.
- Locke, K. and Golden-Biddle, K. (1997), "Constructing opportunities for contribution: structuring intertextual coherence and "problematizing" in organizational studies", *Academy of Management Journal*, Vol. 40 No. 5, pp. 1023-1062.
- Lusch, R.F. and Vargo, S.L. (2010), "S-D logic: accommodating, integrating, transdisciplinary", *Grand Service Challenge*, University of Cambridge, September 23.
- McColl-Kennedy, J.R., Cheung, L. and Ferrier, E. (2015), "Co-creating service experience practices", *Journal of Service Management*, Vol. 26 No. 2, 2015, pp. 249-275.
- McColl-Kennedy, J.R., Hogan, S.J., Witell, L. and Snyder, H. (2017), "Cocreative customer practices: effects of health care customer value cocreation practices on well-being", *Journal of Business Research*, Vol. 70 No. 1, pp. 55-66.
- McColl-Kennedy, J.R., Vargo, S.L., Dagger, T.S., Sweeney, J.C. and van Kasteren, Y. (2012), "Health care customer value cocreation practice styles", *Journal of Service Research*, Vol. 15 No. 4, pp. 370-389.
- MacInnis, D.J. (2011), "A framework for conceptual contributions in marketing", *Journal of Marketing*, Vol. 75 No. 4, pp. 136-154.
- Malthouse, E.C. and Calder, B.J. (2011), "Engagement and experiences: comment on Brodie, Hollebeek, Juric and Ilic (2011)", *Journal of Service Research*, Vol. 14 No. 3, pp. 277-279.
- Malthouse, E.C., Calder, B.J., Kim, S.J. and Vandenbosch, M. (2016), "Evidence that user-generated content that produces engagement increases purchase behaviors", *Journal of Marketing Management*, Vol. 32 Nos 5/63, pp. 427-444.
- McAlexander, J.H., Dufault, B.L., Martin, D.M. and Schouten, J.W. (2014), "The marketization of religion: field, capital, and consumer identity", *Journal of Consumer Research*, Vol. 41 No. 3, pp. 858-875.
- Mollen, A. and Wilson, H. (2010), "Engagement, telepresence, and interactivity in online consumer experience: reconciling scholastic and managerial perspectives", *Journal of Business Research*, Vol. 63 Nos 9/10, pp. 919-925.
- Morgan, G. (1998), *Images of Organization: The Executive Edition*, 2nd ed., Better-Koehler Publishers and SAGE Publications, 1998.
- Ranjan, K.R. and Read, S. (2016), "Value co-creation: concept and measurement", *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, Vol. 44, pp. 290-315.
- Seo, Y., Kelleher, C. and Brodie, R.J. (2017), "Broadening brand engagement within the service-centric perspective: an intersubjective hermeneutic framework", *Journal of Service Theory and Practice*, Vol. 27 No. 2, pp. 317-335.

-
- Storbacka, K., Brodie, R.J., Bohmann, T., Maglio, P.P. and Nenonen, S. (2016), "Actor engagement as a microfoundation for value co-creation", *Journal of Business Research*, Vol. 69 No. 8, pp. 3008-3017.
- Stuart, F.I. and Tax, S. (2004), "Toward an integrative approach to designing service experiences: lessons learned from the theatre", *Journal of Operations Management*, Vol. 22 No. 6, pp. 609-627.
- Van Doorn, J., Lemon, K.E., Mittal, V., Nab, S., Pick, D., Pirner, P. and Verhoef, P.C. (2010), "Customer engagement behavior: theoretical foundations and research directions", *Journal of Service Research*, Vol. 13 No. 3, pp. 253-266.
- Vargo, S.L. (2011), "From micro to macro: stakeholders and institutions", *Journal of Macromarketing*, Vol. 31 No. 2, pp. 125-128.
- Vargo, S.L. and Lusch, R.F. (2008a), "Customer integration and value creation: paradigmatic traps and perspectives", *Journal of Service Research*, Vol. 11 No. 2, pp. 211-215.
- Vargo, S.L. and Lusch, R.F. (2008b), "From goods to service(s): divergences and convergences of logics", *Industrial Marketing Management*, Vol. 37 No. 1, pp. 254-259.
- Vargo, S.L. and Lusch, R.F. (2016a), "Institutions and axioms: an extension and update of service-dominant logic", *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, Vol. 44 No. 1, pp. 5-23.
- Vargo, S.L. and Lusch, R.F. (2016b), "Service-dominant logic 2025", *International Journal of Research in Marketing*, Vol. 34 No. 1, pp. 46-67.
- Verhoef, P.C., Reinartz, W. and Krafft, M. (2010), "Customer engagement as a new perspective in customer management", *Journal of Service Research*, Vol. 13 No. 3, pp. 247-252.
- Vivek, S.D., Beatty, S.E. and Morgan, R.M. (2012), "Consumer engagement: exploring customer relationships beyond purchase", *Journal of Marketing Theory and Practice*, Vol. 20 No. 2, pp. 122-146.
- Warde, A. (2005), "Consumption and theories of practice", *Journal of Consumer Culture*, Vol. 5 No. 2, pp. 131-153.

Further reading

- Brodie, R.J., Ilic, A., Juric, B. and Hollebeek, L. (2013), "Consumer engagement in a virtual brand community: an exploratory analysis", *Journal of Business Research*, Vol. 66 No. 1, pp. 105-114.
- Skålén, P., Aal, K.A. and Edvardsson, B. (2015), "Cocreating the arab spring understanding transformation of service systems in contention", *Journal of Service Research*, Vol. 18 No. 3, pp. 250-264.
- Vargo, S.L. and Lusch, R.F. (2014), "Inversions of service-dominant logic", *Marketing Theory*, Vol. 14 No. 3, pp. 239-248.

Corresponding author

Benjamin Piers William Ellway can be contacted at: ben.ellway@canberra.edu.au